



Grande Arche de la Défense

An elegant symbol of France and an important modern architectural landmark on Paris's Triumphal Way



△ A MIRROR TO THE CITY

Seen at night, the mirrored cladding of the Grande Arche's outer walls reflects the bright lights of La Défense; its white inner surfaces provide a spectacular contrast.

In 1982, President François Mitterrand (1916–1996) launched *Grands Projets Culturels*, an architectural program designed to revitalize Paris and create a series of monuments emblematic of France at the end of the 20th century. Among the eight projects that transformed the Paris skyline over the next 20 years was the Grande Arche de la Défense. It was designed by Danish architect Otto von Spreckelsen and engineer Erik Reitzel, who had competed against 424 others to create a monument for La Défense, a business district west of Paris.

Tribute to the past

Originally known as La Grande Arche de la Fraternité (“the Arch of Fraternity”), the vast cuboid was to be a monument to humanity and friendship. Work began in 1985, with the building of a concrete frame, which was then clad in glass and marble. The arch was inaugurated on July 14, 1989, the 200th anniversary of the French Revolution. The exhibition space, restaurant, and viewing platform were closed in 2010 but reopened in 2017, with a walkway offering views over La Défense and down the Triumphal Way (see panel, right) to the Louvre.

THE TRIUMPHAL WAY

The Grande Arche de la Défense sits at the west end of the Axis Historique, or Triumphal Way, a line of important historic and modern monuments, avenues, and buildings that begins at the Louvre Museum (see p.174). Built above a metro station and expressway, the arch was placed at a slight angle to the axis to allow room for its foundations.

